

6.4 Causes and impacts of migration

Migration is the movement of people across a specified boundary to establish a new permanent place of residence. Sometimes this happens across a country's borders. This is known as **international migration**. A migrant who has moved out of their country is called an **emigrant**. A migrant who has moved into a country is called an **immigrant**.

There has been significant growth in the numbers of people migrating across international borders in the 21st century. In 2020, according to the United Nations Population Fund, 281 million people, or 3.6% of the world's population, were living outside their country of origin. The impact of migration has affected every country either as a place of origin, a place of transit, or as a destination. These consequences are demographic, economic, social, cultural, environmental, and political.

Causes of migration

The reasons for migration are diverse. People migrate due to various **push** and **pull factors** (Table 6.5). Push factors are negative factors that encourage or force people to move from a place. Pull factors are the perceived positive factors that encourage people to move to a place.

Voluntary migration occurs when people freely choose to move. For example, to join their family members, to get a better job, or to improve their lifestyle. Globally, most migrants are **economic migrants**, seeking work and social opportunities. They often send money back to their family, known as migrant **remittances**. In 2019, the International Labour Organization estimated that, globally, there were 169 million international migrant workers, making up nearly 5% of the global labour force.

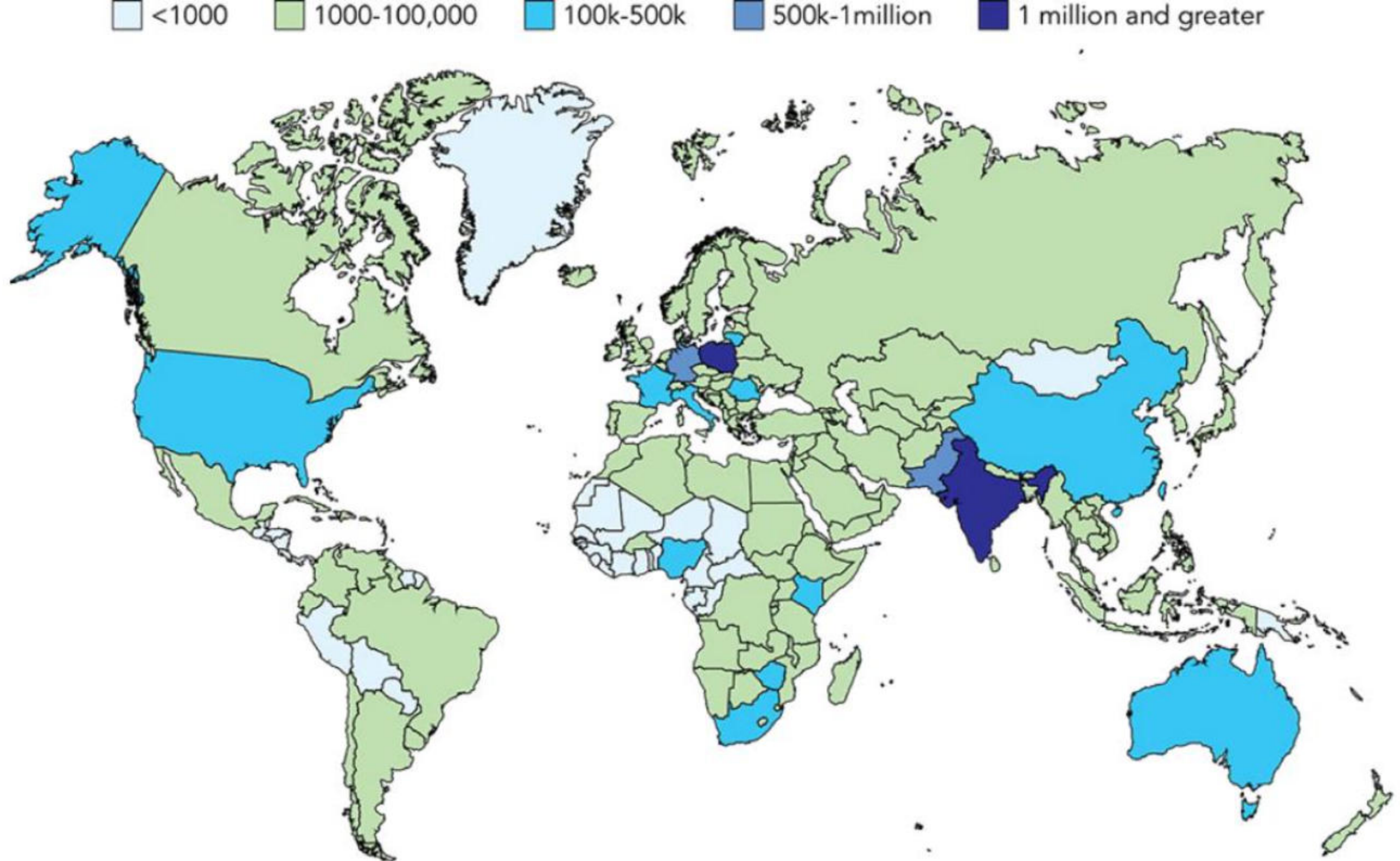
Forced migration occurs when people have no choice but to move. For example, they may be escaping from political conflict (including religious or ethnic persecution) or because of the effects of environmental disasters. A **refugee** is someone who has a well-founded fear of persecution for reasons of race, religion, nationality, political opinion, or membership to a particular social group. They cannot safely return home and are therefore specifically defined and protected in international law. Today, some 52% of all refugees originate from only three countries: Syria, Ukraine, and Afghanistan. Some people leave their country and apply for residence in another country, **seeking asylum** under international law. They are waiting for a decision on their asylum claim in the country they have fled to but haven't yet been legally recognised as a refugee.

TIP

The terms economic migrant, refugee, asylum seeker, immigrant, and emigrant often get confused. Ensure you understand the difference and use the correct terms.

Table 6.5: Push and pull factors causing migration

Push factors	Pull factors
Lack of jobs or poorly paid jobs	Better job opportunities and potential of higher wages
Lack of services such as health, education, and leisure facilities	Better service variety and opportunities
To escape from war or civil unrest	To live in a safer and more politically secure environment
To escape the impacts of a natural disaster	To live in a places less at risk from a natural disaster

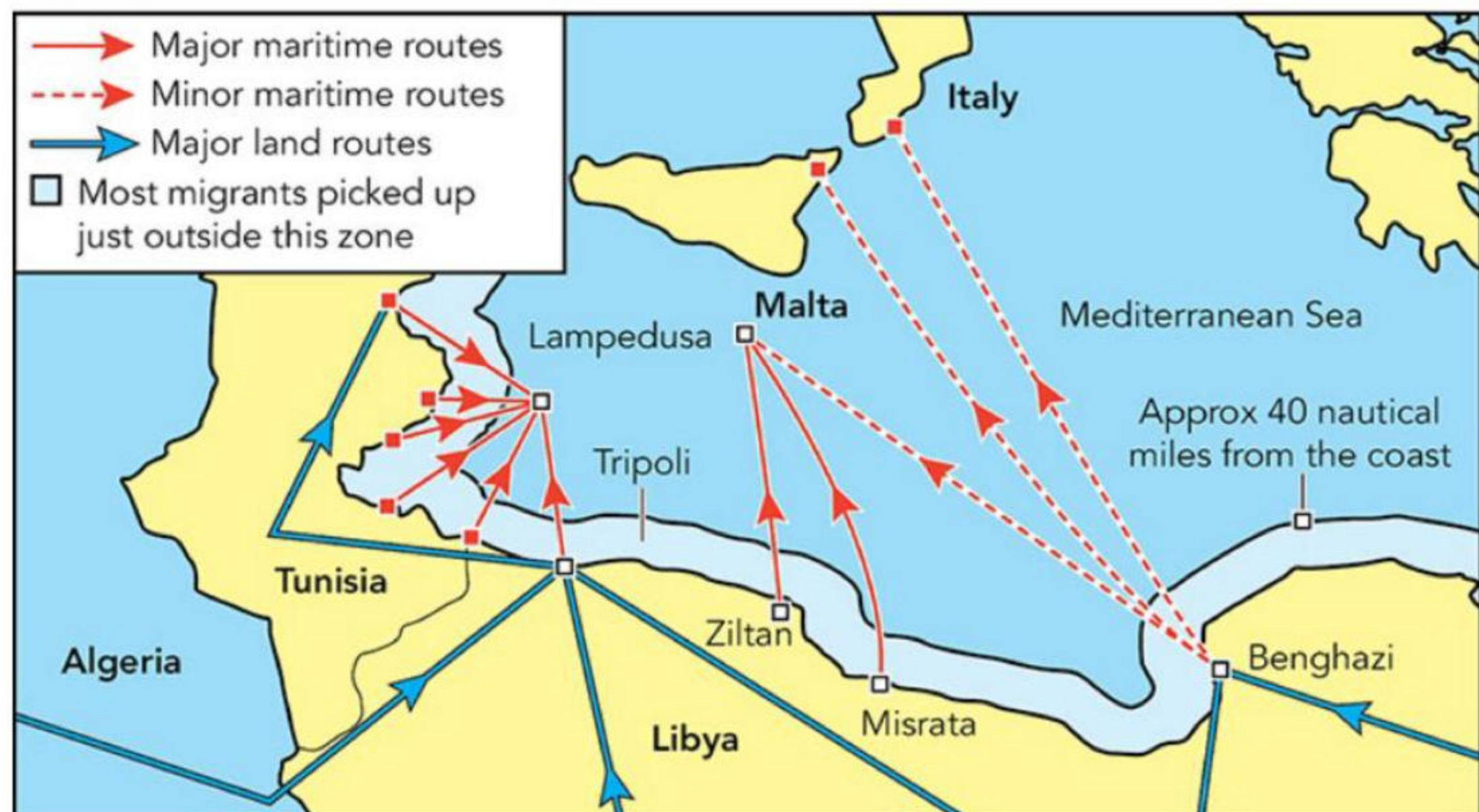


Source A: Top countries of origin for migrants in the UK, 2013

TASK 1: Study Source A

- a Explain the difference between:
 - i immigration and emigration
 - ii voluntary and forced migration
 - iii a refugee and an asylum seeker.
- b Use Source A to **identify the top two countries** of origin for migrants in the UK.
- c Suggest reasons why the UK has a high number of migrants from these top two countries.

Key migration routes from North Africa



TASK 2: Study Source B

- a** Investigate and outline the specific push and pull factors that have caused migration for any one of the routes between North Africa and Europe.
- b** Can you think of any events that might occur that would prevent migrants from reaching their desired destination?

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The impacts of migration

Migrants make meaningful social and economic contributions to **destination countries**. For example, they can lead to a more youthful working population that can boost the economy, often filling skills gaps and shortages in the workforce and contributing to a more balanced age structure and population growth. However, migrants can place additional pressure on services such as education, health and housing, and social conflict may develop between host communities and newcomers.

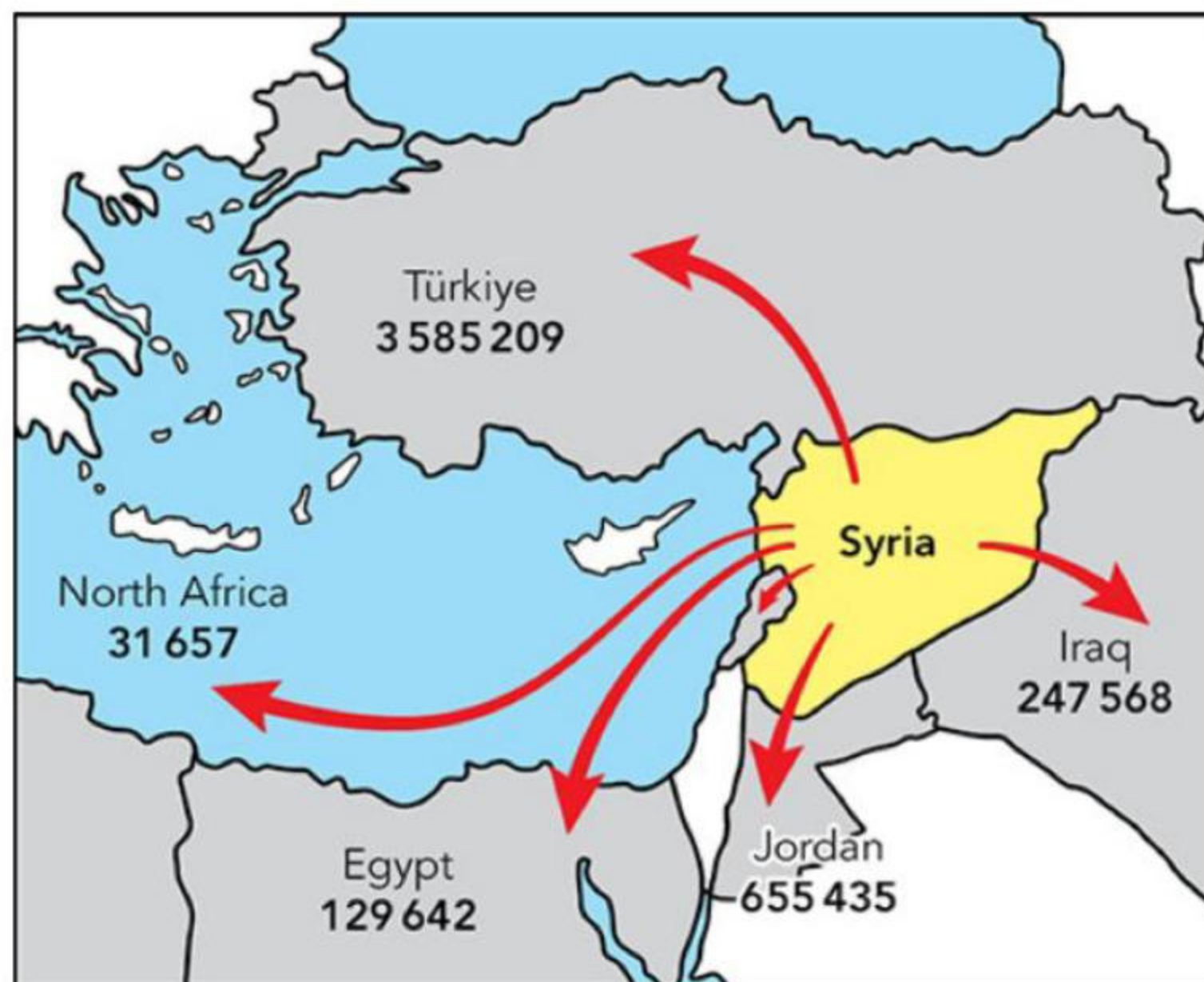
Impacts on the **origin country** include migrants sending money home (remittances) to provide local investment. However, origin countries can lose a proportion of their young, vibrant, and fit part of their labour force — this is referred to as ‘brain drain’.

The decision to migrate can also be a difficult choice to make. The journey for the migrant can be challenging and even life threatening. Migrants often leave behind family and friends in search of a better life.

TASK 3

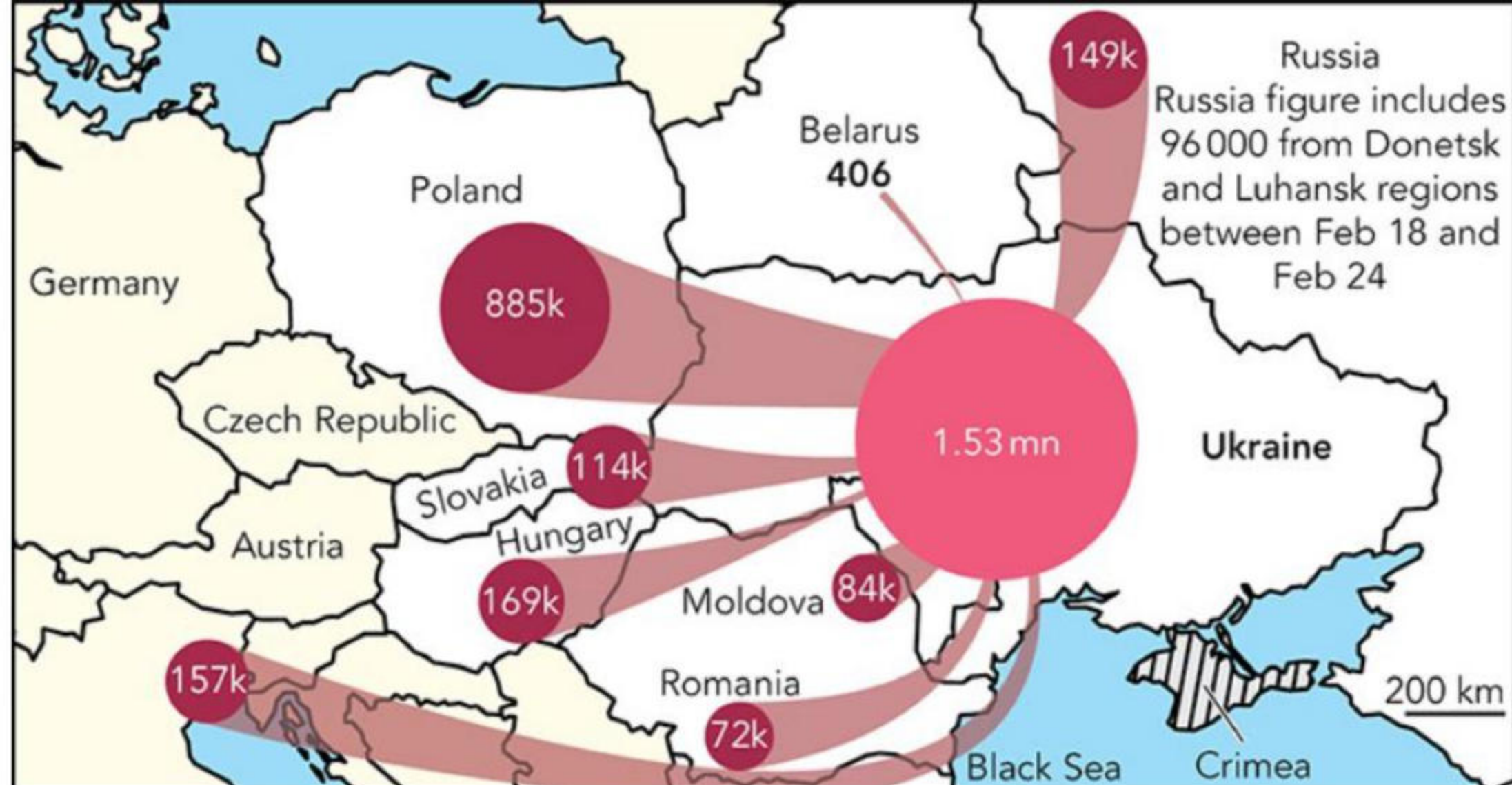
In pairs, discuss each impact to identify if it:

- a** is a ‘positive’ or ‘negative’ impact on the destination country or origin country.
- b** is a ‘demographic’, ‘economic’, ‘social’, or ‘political’ impact.
- c** is an impact on the migrants themselves.
- d** Are there any more impacts that you can think of?



Source **C**: Location of Syrian refugees in neighbouring countries, 2020

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Source D: Location of Ukrainian refugees in neighbouring countries, 24 February to 5 March 2022

TASK 4: Study Sources C D

Research one of these contemporary forced migration movements. In pairs, create a poster to present to the rest of the class. In your poster you should:

- Outline the causes of forced migration.
- Identify where people are fleeing to.
- Make a table of the impacts of forced migration on:
 - the country of origin
 - the destination country/countries
 - the migrants themselves.

Management of migration

The size, complexity, and impact of migration make it a priority issue for governments of most nations. Migration policies, border control, and migrant safety are increasingly important issues because it is a global phenomenon, not just in demographic terms, but also as a global social and political issue. Governments have many responsibilities, and monitoring and managing the population of their country is very important. Depending on population change in a country, governments can either discourage migrants or encourage migrants.

Governments design national migration policies to meet the economic, social, and political needs of a country.

Deterring illegal migration

Increased border controls and building physical barriers are a method of deterring illegal migration. Between the border of Mexico and the United States, for example, there are a series of vertical barriers aimed at preventing illegal crossings from Mexico into the USA. Between the physical barriers there is a virtual fence of sensors and cameras which, are monitored by US Border Patrol. Although the barrier is effective at certain points, due to the rough and remote mountainous and desert terrain, it would be very expensive to construct and maintain a physical barrier. You can read more about this in DSE 6.5.

In 2023, the UK government's Illegal Migration Act changed the law so that those who arrive in the UK illegally will not be able to stay and instead will be detained and then removed, either to their country of origin or a safe third country. The UK government signed a deal to send people seeking asylum in the UK to Rwanda. It was hoped that this would help put a stop to illegal migration, stop people making dangerous small boat crossings across the English channel, speed up the removal of those without the right to live in the UK, and better support those in genuine need of resettlement in the UK. The UK's Supreme Court deemed the scheme unlawful. In 2024, the scheme was scrapped by a newly appointed government.

Developing legal pathways to migration

Some countries have migration policies to encourage immigration. For example, some countries use a points-based system designed to satisfy labour shortages in key sectors. Singapore, for example, is keen to attract more overseas workers because of a fall in migration to the country during the COVID-19 pandemic. Singapore operates a points-based system (known as COMPASS – Figure 6.2). However, the system favours highly educated, high earning, and skilled workers in industries such as finance and technology, which are the priority industries of the Singaporean government.

Promoting emigration

Some countries, such as Pakistan, actively encourage emigration to assist with development through the financial benefits of migrant remittances and skills and ideas brought back by returning migrants.

Compass Criteria	
C1 Salary	- Salary relative to the local PMET salary norms for the sector - Earn up to 20 points
C2 Qualification	- Based on the applicant's education qualifications - Earn up to 20 points
C3 Diversity	- Whether the applicant improves the diversity of the firm - Earn up to 20 points
C4 Local Employment	- Based on the firm's employment of local PMET relative to the industry - Earn up to 20 points
Bonus Criteria	- C5. Skills bonus - C6. Strategic economic priorities
Applicant must score a total of 40 points to pass compass	

Figure 6.2: Singapore's new points-based framework to determine foreign workers' eligibility for employment

THINK LIKE A GEOGRAPHER

Managing migration is complex. If you were in charge of designing a points-based system for allowing migrants into your country, what criteria would you use?